

Alternative energy

There are several types of alternative energy, some of which are also renewable (see opposite page).

Wind

Mounted on tall masts, huge rotating blades called wind turbines harness the wind's energy and use it to drive electricity generators.

Solar

The sun's energy can be used to heat water in homes or to produce high temperatures for electricity generation. Photovoltaic panels convert sunlight directly into electricity.

Nuclear

The nuclei (cores) of atoms are split apart in nuclear power plants, releasing vast amounts of energy. However, the process also creates dangerous nuclear waste.

Geothermal

A geothermal power plant taps underground steam or hot water, which it uses to generate electricity or to heat buildings directly.

Hydroelectric

A hydroelectric power plant is a dam with generators built into it. Water builds up behind the dam. When gates in the dam are opened, the force of the falling water drives the generators.

Biofuel, biogas, and biomass

Liquid fuel made from plants, rather than oil, is called biofuel. When farm waste, sewage, and garbage rot, they release biogas, which can be burned as fuel. Biomass is any plant-based material burned for warmth or to generate electricity.

Alternative energy

Burning fossil fuels—coal, oil, and gas—creates a lot of pollution. People are developing alternative, cleaner energy sources, and some are renewable—they never run out.

